

Northerners, South Carolina was more responsible than any other state for the suffering the nation had endured for nearly four years.

Natural obstacles

The logistical problems of marching an army through the swamps and rain-swollen rivers that lay between Savannah, Georgia, and South Carolina's state capital, Columbia, presented a greater challenge than did the Confederate troops. In many places the roads were impassable, and Sherman's men had to create causeways by the slow process of "corduroying." This entailed cutting down trees, stripping off the bark, and flattening them on one side, then laying them crosswise, interspersed with saplings, to form a usable surface for the men and the supply wagons. In spite of the difficulties, Sherman's bummers made extraordinarily fast progress, covering almost 10 miles (16km) a day. By February 17, barely a month after leaving Savannah, they reached Columbia. That night, the city burned. By the following morning, two-thirds of it lay in ashes.

The fate of Columbia was only part of the trail of destruction Sherman's forces blazed across the state. In their path they looted farms and torched villages to the ground. The Confederate forces opposing them felt the pinch because they were forced to live off the land as best they could.

On February 23, at Robert E. Lee's insistence, Joseph Johnston took command of Southern forces in the Carolinas. Under the circumstances, the best that he could manage was a holding action designed to delay Sherman's progress.

From Columbia, the Union commander headed north toward Goldsboro, North Carolina, where he expected to rendezvous with 20,000 additional Federal troops under General John M. Schofield, marching from the Confederate port of Wilmington, recently captured after the Battle of Fort Fisher.

458 The number of buildings estimated to have been burned in South Carolina's capital Columbia, including six churches, eleven banks, and a printing plant where Confederate currency was minted.